HISTORY/CULTURE

SMELTED IDENTITIES

What does 'tribal' mean? At best it's an ensemble of archetypes, each one more problematic than the other

By SUNIL MENON

'TRIBAL'. The word teems with life, like a forest of meanings. Its very arrival sets off in our minds a sensory explosion. Colour, sound, feel—a rich, compound expressivity. But what does it mean really? Here we trail off into a zone of semantic ambiguity. Neither average townsfolk—equipped with a sense of the self as 'non-tribal'—nor scientist will be able to supply an exact meaning. That's because it lacks one. The most anyone can do is tap into an ensemble of archetypes: primitive and/or unsophisticated, savage, tightly-knit communities living isolated in forest, desert or savannah, away from the systems of rationality that built civilisations.

Each of those is problematic. Take 'irrational'. An environmentalist travelling to the uplands by the Narmada in the mid-'90s was astounded to see the local Bhils making river water flow *uphill*—using a series of strategically created depressions to aid the flow in their 'pat' irrigation system! Consider 'primitive'. Iron was first smelted in India, in the second millennium BC, by people you would now call tribals, all across the land. From sites dotting the Deccan to the Netarhat hills in Jharkhand and the Kaimur range, south of Banaras—the bloomery furnace still used by the Asura and Agaria people there is what made the Iron Pillar of Asoka, which stands unrusted by time. "Itinerants of the forest in 800 BC had access to state-of-the-art military technology," writes historian Sumit Guha, in a wry aside in *Environment & Ethnicity in India*. As for the ascription of 'savagery' to tribal peoples, speaking after a century of the most mechanised systems of mass human killing invented, the irony there *is* savage. Just like Anglo-Saxons presuming to call others 'criminal tribes'.

Empires rose from tribal communities. The Sakas were horseback archers from the Steppes, the Kushanas were the Yuezhi, the Hoysalas were Malenadu tribals



INDIA PICTURE

Toda temple in the Nilgiris

Take non-material culture. The people who composed the Vedas—whom you would now *not* think of as tribals—were pastoral nomads wandered off from the Sintashta culture of Central Asia, entering a phase of sedentarisation. The Buddha was born among the Shakyas, a republican clan with elected leadership and forms of egalitarianism that strongly suggest 'tribal' political ideals—ideals that flowed into Buddhist conception of the Sangha, as Guha writes. St Augustine, as key a figure in western philosophy as in Christian theology, was a Berber from North Africa. And more and more scholars are tracing the European Enlightenment ideals of "liberty, fraternity, equality" to ideas expressed by Huron chief Kondiaronk, in conversations with a French soldier-explorer, Baron Lahontan, in 16th century Canada. From Voltaire to Rousseau, everyone seems to have ingested a bit of trans-Atlantic native wisdom.

'Isolation' from the mainstream is, by scholarly consensus, a product of interaction rather than the lack of it. The Harappan cultures and contemporary Neolithic cultures had robust contact—up to north Deccan sites like Jorwe, perhaps up to Maski in north Karnataka, they all existed in a network